

(From left sitting) **Raj Chengappa,** *Group editorial director, India Today;* **Naveen Patnaik,** *Odisha chief minister; and* **Suresh Mahapatra,** *Chief secretary, Odisha government with the India Today State of the State Odisha 2022 best district winners*

STATE OF THE STATE CONCLAVE
ODISHA 2022

RISING FROM THE CHURN

The India Today State of the State Odisha awards were clear vindication of the transformative journey the state has undertaken

By Romita Datta

Odisha has come a long way from those harrowing days of the Super Cyclone in 1999 when a 25-year-old district collector of Cuttack, Pradip Jena (now 48 and additional chief secretary, revenue and disaster management), was running helter-skelter to arrange safe shelter for the people and restore power. Today, it is the first state in the country to have an independent Odisha Disaster Management Authority and its own rapid response team. Indeed, its expertise is such that it helps other states navigate storms and natural calamities. Odisha also now prides itself on having a GSDP growth of 10.1 per cent as against the national GDP growth of 8.8 per cent in 2021-22. From a BIMARU state, it has taken giant strides to emerge as a role model for others in sectors as diverse as disaster management, health, education, skill development, industry and women's empowerment.

Success has come after much sweat, labour and perseverance, and is that much sweeter for it. Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik flits past the unpleasant memories from when he first took over two decades ago. "Development had come to a halt and Odisha was hitting the news for all the wrong reasons," he reminisced with a faint smile playing on his face.

But the CM was committed to fulfilling the aspira-